The next morning, I boarded my train to Avadi in Chennai and reached home by afternoon. Papaji had come to pick me up. All this while, I had dealt with mixed feelings, consumed by both joy and gloom. But everyone else was happy and proud that I had been recommended in my first SSB interview and kept cheering me. Maa had made aloo paranthas—my favourite—but I had lost all appetite.

'Don't worry, you can eat today. We'll work on your weight loss from tomorrow,' Papaji consoled me.

'I always told you she was fat and lazy,' Dada commented rather playfully.

'Not in the mood, Dada,' I retorted. Dada went back to eating his paranthas.

'It's just a few kilos,' Maa said.

'It's not about my weight, Maa,' I said in frustration. I was reminded of the possibility that I might never be eligible to fly. I thought it better to get up and go to my room than spread more pessimism around the dining table. Knowing that I would have to spend the next four weeks in uncertainty added to my frustration. If that wasn't all, I had almost started to believe I *actually* was unfit to fly. Weight can be lost, but height cannot be gained, especially at my age. A cycle of negative thoughts was set in motion. Visions of spending my service days, if at all I was allowed to join the forces, on the ground started to storm my mind. Tears of disappointment trickled down my face as I lay in my bed.

'So you've given up already?' Papaji said as he stood by the door. I dug my face deeper into the pillow. He came and sat by my side, placing his hand gently on my head.

'You're going to wear a uniform soon,' he said. 'Men and women in uniform do not know how to give up. Besides, these little hurdles are part of your SSB interview. The Indian Air Force wants to know how resolute you are before they offer you command over their men and machines.' I had almost stopped crying. He continued, 'Once you wear the rank, you'll come across situations that will break you. There's no shame in falling, but there is no glory in not trying to get up after the fall. You may have to go to war.